Oxford College of Emory University

Chapter 13: Fiscal Policy

Government Purchases, Taxes, and Transfers

ECON_OX 112 · Principles of Macroeconomics

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U.S. Government Receipts, 2025

Federal, state, and local governments · Calendar year · Trillions of dollars



Current receipts totaled $8.80 trillion. Borrowing is separate.

Taxes include personal, corporate, and production/import taxes.

Source: BEA, September 2026 annual update · 2025 government accounts

U.S. Government Purchases and Benefits, 2025

Federal, state, and local governments · Calendar year · Trillions of dollars



About 64% of government purchases were made by state and local governments.

Benefits include cash and benefits in kind. These selected flows are not all government outlays.

Source: BEA, September 2026 annual update · 2025 government accounts

Roadmap

Policy goals and instruments

Purchases, household taxes, and transfers

Demand and policy limits

Expansion, contraction, criticisms, and delays

The multiplier

Initial spending and successive consumption rounds

Automatic stabilization

Existing rules versus new policy decisions

Fiscal Policy and Stabilization

Definition

Government decisions about purchases, taxes, and transfers.

Stabilization goal

Support output and employment in a recession; restrain excess demand in a boom.

Policy direction

Expansionary policy raises AD; contractionary policy reduces AD.

Public services and redistribution are also fiscal goals.

Fiscal Instruments

Instrument	Example	Immediate channel
Purchases (G)	Road maintenance	A purchase of current output
Transfers (TR)	Unemployment benefits	Household disposable income
Household taxes (T)	Personal income taxes	Household disposable income

Transfers are not G. Public infrastructure investment is G; I is private investment.

GDP accounting: BEA

Fiscal Policy and Aggregate Expenditure

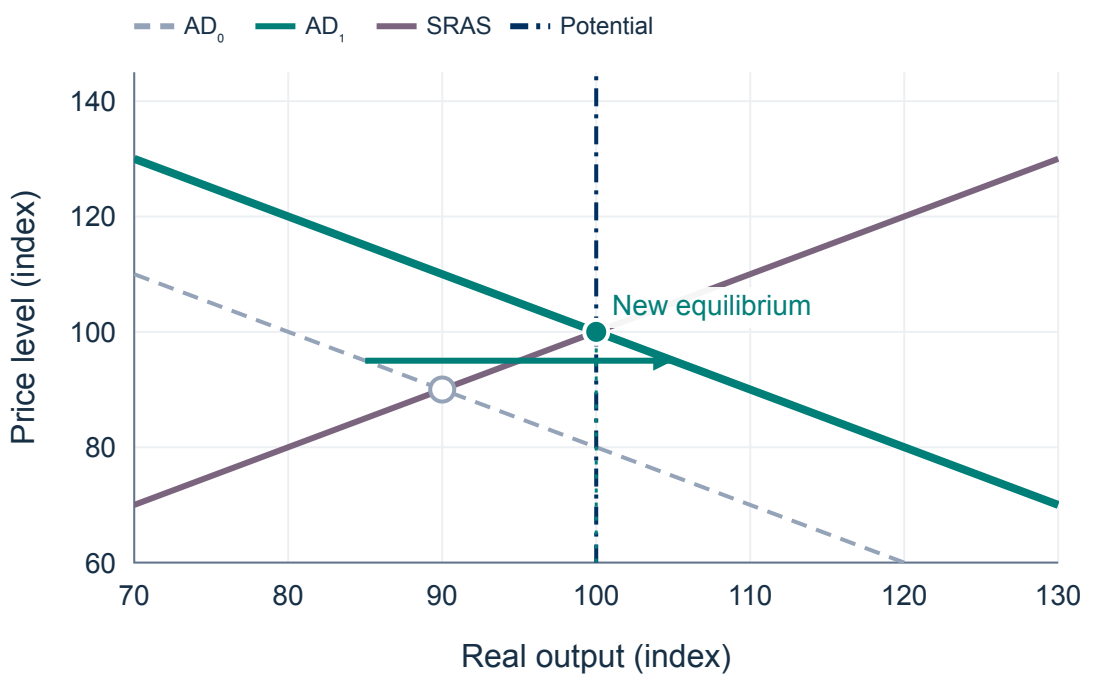
$$Y = C + I + G + NX$$

C: Consumption	Household taxes and transfers change disposable income. Tax cuts or higher transfers can raise C.
I: Private investment	Business tax incentives and expected sales affect investment. Borrowing can also raise financing costs and weaken I.
G: Government purchases	Government buys current goods and services. The direct expenditure channel.
NX: Net exports	Higher domestic spending can increase imports. Imports reduce NX, other things equal.

Expansionary Fiscal Policy

Starting output = 90 · Potential output = 100

Expansionary · AD increases



Recessionary gap

Output is below potential.

Policy change

Government purchases increase.

Demand response

AD shifts right; production rises.

New equilibrium

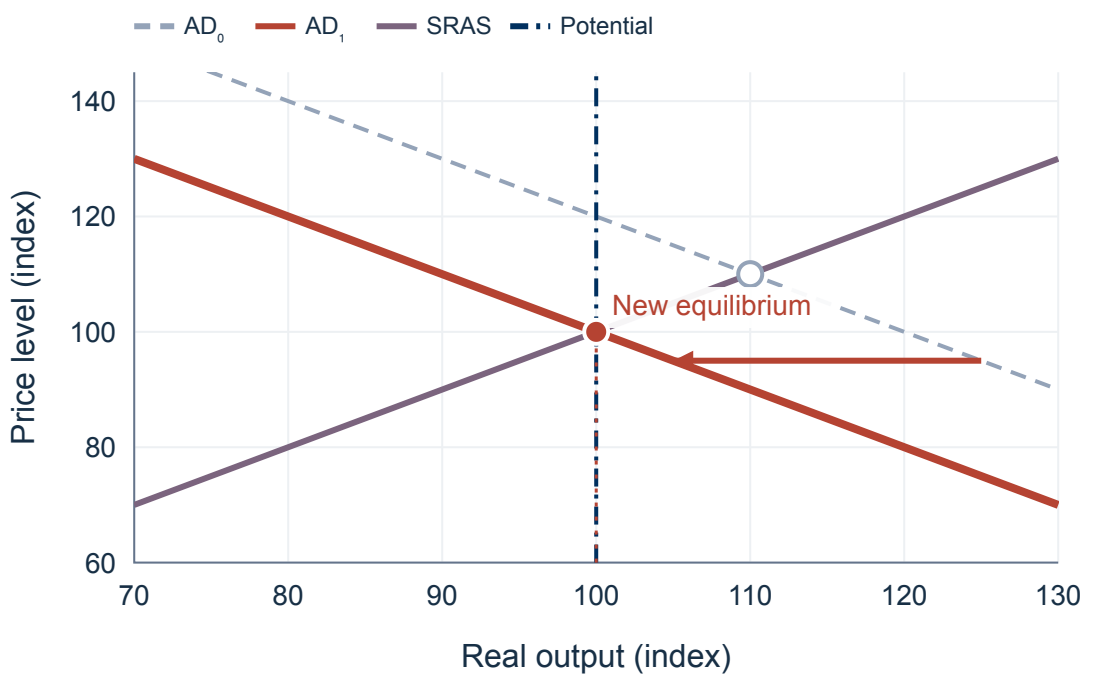
Output reaches 100; the price level rises.

Expansionary alternatives: G ↑, household T ↓, or TR ↑.

Contractionary Fiscal Policy

Starting output = 110 · Potential output = 100

Contractionary · AD decreases



Inflationary gap

Output is above potential.

Policy change

Government purchases decrease.

Demand response

AD shifts left; production falls.

New equilibrium

Output returns to 100; the price level falls.

Contractionary alternatives: G ↓, household T ↑, or TR ↓.

Fiscal Policy Checkpoint

Identify the policy direction and the immediate spending channel.

A. Output is below potential; government repairs more roads.

Expansionary. Purchases directly increase G.

B. Output is above potential; household income taxes rise.

Contractionary. Disposable income and consumption fall.

Three Criticisms of Fiscal Expansion

Criticism	Mechanism	Qualification
Investment crowding out	Borrowing can raise interest rates and reduce I.	The size depends on economic and monetary conditions.
Consumption offset	Current tax financing can reduce disposable income and C.	The reduction need not cancel the extra G.
Ricardian equivalence	A tax cut may be saved for expected future taxes.	A conditional tax-timing argument, holding spending fixed.

An offset can weaken a policy without eliminating its effect.

References: CBO fiscal-policy framework; CRS fiscal-policy review

Fiscal Policy Lags: The 2008–2009 Response

Recognition

Diagnose the shock.

Decision

Choose and authorize a response.

Implementation

Deliver purchases or payments.

15 Sep 2008

Lehman bankruptcy

26 Jan 2009

Recovery bill introduced

17 Feb 2009

ARRA signed

May 2009

$250 benefit payments

Authorization and delivery occur at different times.

Sources: Federal Reserve History; Congress.gov (H.R. 1); Social Security Administration

The Spending Multiplier

The first payment becomes income

A government purchase pays a worker or supplier.

Some income is spent again

Recipients consume part and save part of the extra income.

Further rounds become smaller

New consumption creates more income; saving limits the chain.

The output change combines the first spending change and the later rounds.

Government Purchases: Successive Spending Rounds

ΔG = +$100 billion · MPC = 0.8 · Fixed price level

Government purchases

+$100 billion

The initial purchase is income for workers and suppliers.

First spending

$100 billion

Next consumption round

0.8 × $100 = $80 billion

Further consumption rounds

$64 billion + $51.2 billion + …

Total ΔY = $500 billion $k_G = 1/(1 - 0.8) = 5$

Fixed taxes and transfers; no imports or investment offsets.

A Household Tax Cut

Household taxes fall by $100 billion · MPC = 0.8

Disposable income rises

$\Delta T = -\$100$ billion; $\Delta Y_D = +\$100$ billion.

Households consume part

Initially, consumption rises $80 billion and saving rises $20 billion.

Later rounds add to output

$\Delta Y = \$80 \text{ billion} \times 5 = +\$400$ billion.

The tax multiplier has a negative sign

$k_T = -4$, so $\Delta Y = (-4) \times (-\$100 \text{ billion}) = +\$400$ billion.

Purchases, Tax Cuts, and Transfers

MPC = 0.8 · Change one instrument at a time

Expansionary change	First channel	Initial expenditure
G increases by $100 billion	Government purchases	+$100 billion in G
Household T falls by $100 billion	Disposable income +$100 billion	+$80 billion in C
TR increases by $100 billion	Disposable income +$100 billion	+$80 billion in C

Transfers affect GDP when recipients spend them; the payment itself is not G.

Fiscal Multipliers

MPC = 0.8 · Fixed price level · One policy change at a time

Expansionary change	First spending	Multiplier	Equilibrium ΔY
ΔG = +$100 billion	+$100 billion	$k_G = 5$	+$500 billion
ΔT = −$100 billion	+$80 billion	$k_T = -4$	+$400 billion
ΔTR = +$100 billion	+$80 billion	$k_{TR} = 4$	+$400 billion

$k_G = 1/(1 - MPC)$ $k_T = -MPC/(1 - MPC)$ $k_{TR} = MPC/(1 - MPC)$

A $500 billion gap: ΔG = $500 billion ÷ 5 = $100 billion.

Recipients and Policy Design

An additional $100 of disposable income

Recipient	MPC	Initial consumption
Household A	0.8	$80
Household B	0.4	$40

Consider spending, delivery speed, distribution, and the value of public purchases.

Income Taxes and the Multiplier

MPC = 0.8 · Income-tax rate t = 25% · Fixed price level

Additional output		Taxes and disposable income		Additional consumption
$\Delta Y = \$100$	$\rightarrow$	$\Delta T = \$25$ $\quad \Delta Y_D = \$75$	$\rightarrow$	$\Delta C = 0.8 \times \$75 = \$60$

Only \$60 reaches the next spending round, compared with \$80 under fixed taxes.

MPC remains 0.8; MPS remains 0.2.

$k_G = 1 / [1 - MPC(1 - t)]$

$k_G = 1 / [1 - 0.8(0.75)] =$ **2.5**, compared with **5** under fixed taxes.

Automatic Stabilizers

Income falls

Tax payments fall under existing income-tax rules.

Unemployment rises

More eligible workers receive existing benefits.

Consumption is cushioned

Disposable income falls by less than it otherwise would.

No new law is needed for these responses.

Fiscal Policy: Final Checkpoint

Explain the mechanism, not just the label.

A. Income falls; the tax schedule stays unchanged.

Automatic stabilization: tax payments fall.

B. A new law raises weekly unemployment benefits.

Discretionary expansion: transfers increase.

C. With MPC = 0.8, compare a $100 purchase and a $100 tax cut.

Purchases: $\Delta Y = \$500$. Tax cut: $\Delta Y = \$400$; the first round is smaller.